

World fairs

The success of the Great Exhibition in 1851 in London inspired other countries to follow suit, promoting national successes and displaying their latest developments in science, technology and the arts. From mid-century on, major world fairs took place in several US cities and across the capitals of Europe. Fairs gave architects opportunities to present a nation's idealized version of the future. Chicago's Century of Progress fair (1933), for instance, included the steel-framed House of Tomorrow, designed by George Keck (1895–1980) to include an aircraft hangar as well as a garage; and the Armco-Ferro House, whose revolutionary prefabricated construction was designed for mass production. On a larger scale, examples of iconic structures from world fairs include Gustave Eiffel's eponymous tower (1889), and the Grand Palais in Paris (1900), designed by a team of four architects. Ludwig Mies van der Rohe (1886–1969), designed the German Pavilion for the 1929 exposition in Barcelona; despite extravagant materials, its simple form led to it becoming regarded as an important modernist building.

